

The Recipe Vault · Vol. 01

Cake Studio

Bake, fill, frost and decorate

SchoolAura

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CHAPTER

Before you bake

Good cakes come from a few habits more than from secret recipes. Read this chapter once, and every recipe in this book will work better.

Weigh, don't scoop

Every recipe gives grams first, with cups as a backup. A cup of flour can weigh anywhere from 120 g to 160 g depending on how you fill it, which is the difference between a tender cake and a dry one. A digital kitchen scale costs less than a cake tin and removes the guesswork.

If you must use cups, **spoon the flour into the cup and level it with a knife**. Never dip the cup into the bag.

Room temperature matters

Butter, eggs and milk should sit out for about an hour before baking, so they blend into a smooth batter that traps air.

- **Butter** is ready when your finger leaves a dent but doesn't sink in (about 18–20°C / 65–68°F). Too soft and the cake will be dense and greasy.
- **Eggs:** place cold eggs in a bowl of warm tap water for 10 minutes.
- **Milk or buttermilk:** microwave in 10-second bursts until no longer cold.

Know your oven

Most home ovens run 10–25°F (5–15°C) hotter or cooler than the dial says. An **oven thermometer** placed in the middle of the oven tells you the truth. Always preheat for at least 20 minutes, and bake on the middle rack.

Prepare your pans

Grease the pan, line the base with a circle of parchment, grease the parchment, then dust with flour (or cocoa for chocolate cakes). Your layers will release cleanly every time.

Bake-even strips (wet fabric strips wrapped around the pan) help layers bake flat with less doming, so there's less to level off later.

Mixing methods

- **Creaming method** (butter cakes): beat butter and sugar for 3–4 minutes until pale and fluffy, add eggs one at a time, then alternate dry ingredients and liquid. Gives a light, classic crumb.

- **Oil method** (chocolate, carrot, red velvet): whisk wet ingredients, then stir into dry. Gives a moist cake that stays soft in the fridge.
- **Reverse creaming:** mix butter into the dry ingredients first, then add liquids. Gives a fine, velvety crumb that's very stable for stacking.

Once flour is added, **mix only until you can't see dry flour**. Over-mixing makes cakes tough and tunnelled.

How to tell when it's done

- The top springs back when pressed lightly.
- The edges pull away from the sides of the pan.
- A toothpick in the centre comes out clean or with a few moist crumbs (not wet batter).

Cool layers in the pan for 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack. Cool completely before frosting. **For decorating, chill layers wrapped in plastic for at least 2 hours, or overnight.** Cold cakes are much easier to level, stack and frost.

Changing pan sizes

Use the pan's area to scale a recipe. The two-layer 8-inch recipes in this book fill:

PAN	APPROX. AREA	BATTER VS. TWO 8-INCH ROUNDS	BAKE TIME (APPROX.)
Two 8-inch rounds	100 sq in	1× (as written)	28–35 min
Two 9-inch rounds	127 sq in	1.25×	25–32 min
Three 6-inch rounds	85 sq in	0.85×	22–28 min
9 × 13 inch rectangle	117 sq in	1.15×	30–40 min
24 cupcakes	—	1×	18–22 min

Thinner layers bake faster. Always check 5 minutes before the shortest time.

Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX NEXT TIME
Domed, cracked top	Oven too hot, too much batter	Check oven temperature; use bake-even strips
Sank in the middle	Underbaked, oven door opened early, too much leavening	Bake until it springs back; don't open the door for the first 20 min
Dry and crumbly	Too much flour, overbaked	Weigh flour; check early; brush layers with syrup
Dense and heavy	Butter too soft or cold, under-creamed	Room-temperature ingredients; cream for a full 3–4 min
Stuck to the pan	Pan not lined	Grease, parchment, grease, flour
Tunnels and holes	Over-mixed after adding flour	Mix just until combined

CHAPTER

Tools & equipment

You don't need everything on day one. Start with the essentials, add the decorating kit when you're ready, and buy the extras for special projects.



Turntable



Offset spatula



Bench scraper



Cake leveler



Piping bags



Piping tips + coupler



Cake boards



Dowels / straws



Straight-sided pans



Digital scale



Oven thermometer



Fondant smoother



Stand or hand mixer



Silicone spatula



Cooling rack



Gel colours

The core decorating kit. Most pieces cost under $15 each.

The essentials

TOOL	WHY YOU NEED IT	BUYING TIP
Digital scale	Accurate flour and sugar, consistent results	One that switches between grams and ounces, with a tare button
Two 8-inch round pans	The standard layer cake size	Straight sides, at least 2 in (5 cm) deep, light-coloured aluminium
Stand or hand mixer	Creaming butter and whipping cream	A hand mixer is fine to start
Silicone spatula	Folding and scraping the bowl	Get two
Cooling rack	Air underneath stops soggy bases	Wire grid style
Oven thermometer	Your oven dial is probably wrong	Hangs from the rack
Parchment paper	Clean release every time	Pre-cut circles save time

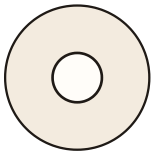
The decorating kit

TOOL	WHY YOU NEED IT	BUYING TIP
Turntable	Smooth sides and even piping	A heavy metal or cast-iron base spins steadily
Offset spatula (small and large)	Spreading filling and frosting	The bent blade keeps your knuckles out of the cake
Bench scraper / cake comb	Smooth, straight sides	Stainless steel, at least as tall as your cake
Cake leveler or serrated knife	Flat, even layers	A wire leveler is cheap and easy
Cake boards	A firm base to move and stack cakes	Get boards the same size as your cake, plus thicker drums for display
Piping bags	Piping borders and decorations	Disposable 16-inch bags are easiest
Piping tips + coupler	Different shapes from one bag	Start with round #12, open star 1M, closed star 2D, petal #104, leaf #352
Gel food colours	Strong colour without thinning frosting	Gels or pastes, not liquid drops

For bigger projects

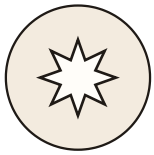
Fondant smoother, rolling pin, cake dowels or bubble-tea straws, a cake lifter, a palette knife set, flower nail, cake boxes, and an acrylic disc set for very sharp edges.

Piping tips at a glance



Round #12

dots, pearls, writing, borders



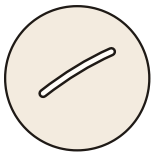
Open star 1M

rosettes, swirls, cupcakes



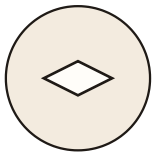
Closed star 2D

drop flowers, deep ridges



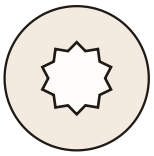
Petal #104

ruffles, roses, swags



Leaf #352

leaves for flowers



French star 6B

soft ridged swirls

Six tips that cover almost every design in this book.

CHAPTER

The cake bases

Seven reliable cakes, all sturdy enough for stacking and decorating. Each makes two 8-inch layers unless noted. Bake them ahead: wrapped well, cooled layers keep in the fridge for 3 days or the freezer for 2 months.

CAKE BASE — RECIPE 01

Classic Vanilla Butter Cake

The everyday birthday cake. A tender, buttery crumb that's sturdy enough to stack and decorate.

Makes two 8-inch layers · Serves 12–14 · Prep 25 min · Bake 28–32 min · 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 315 g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 2½ tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp fine salt
- 226 g (1 cup) unsalted butter, room temperature
- 350 g (1¾ cups) granulated sugar
- 4 large eggs, room temperature
- 1 tbsp pure vanilla extract
- 240 ml (1 cup) whole milk, room temperature

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line two 8-inch round pans.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder and salt in a bowl.
3. Beat the butter and sugar on medium-high speed for 3–4 minutes until pale and fluffy. Scrape the bowl.
4. Add the eggs one at a time, beating well after each. Beat in the vanilla.
5. On low speed, add the flour mixture in three parts, alternating with the milk in two parts, starting and ending with flour. Mix only until no dry flour remains.
6. Divide evenly between the pans (weigh them for equal layers) and smooth the tops.
7. Bake for 28–32 minutes, until golden and a toothpick comes out clean.
8. Cool in the pans for 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack to cool completely.

NOTES

- For a whiter cake, use 6 egg whites instead of 4 whole eggs, and clear vanilla.
- Brush cooled layers with Simple Syrup (see Frostings & fillings) to keep them moist under fondant.

Rich Chocolate Fudge Cake

Deep, dark and very moist thanks to oil and hot coffee. It stays soft even when chilled, so it's ideal for decorated cakes.

Makes two 8-inch layers | Serves 14 | Prep 15 min | Bake 32–38 min | 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 400 g (2 cups) granulated sugar
- 220 g (1¾ cups) all-purpose flour
- 65 g (¾ cup) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1½ tsp baking powder
- 1½ tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp fine salt
- 2 large eggs, room temperature
- 240 ml (1 cup) whole milk
- 120 ml (½ cup) vegetable oil
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 240 ml (1 cup) hot coffee or boiling water

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line two 8-inch pans, and dust with cocoa.
2. In a large bowl, whisk the sugar, flour, cocoa, baking powder, baking soda and salt.
3. Add the eggs, milk, oil and vanilla. Beat on medium speed for 2 minutes.
4. Stir in the hot coffee by hand. The batter will be very thin; that's correct.
5. Pour into the pans and bake for 32–38 minutes, until a toothpick comes out with a few moist crumbs.
6. Cool for 10 minutes in the pans, then turn out onto a rack.

NOTES

- Coffee deepens the chocolate flavour; the cake won't taste of coffee.
- Use this base for the Black Forest cake and the Birthday Drip Cake project.

Red Velvet Cake

A soft, slightly tangy cake with a hint of cocoa. Traditionally paired with cream cheese frosting.

Makes two 8-inch layers | Serves 14 | Prep 20 min | Bake 28–34 min | 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 315 g (2½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 300 g (1½ cups) granulated sugar
- 1 tbsp (7 g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp fine salt
- 360 ml (1½ cups) vegetable oil
- 240 ml (1 cup) buttermilk, room temperature
- 2 large eggs, room temperature
- 1–2 tbsp red gel food colour
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tsp white vinegar

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line two 8-inch pans.
2. Whisk the flour, sugar, cocoa, baking soda and salt in a large bowl.
3. In another bowl, whisk the oil, buttermilk, eggs, food colour, vanilla and vinegar until smooth.
4. Pour the wet mixture into the dry and whisk just until smooth.
5. Divide between the pans and bake for 28–34 minutes, until the centre springs back.
6. Cool for 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack.

NOTES

- No buttermilk? Stir 1 tbsp lemon juice into 1 cup of milk and leave for 5 minutes.
- Gel colour gives a deep red without the bitter taste of large amounts of liquid colour.

Spiced Carrot Cake

Moist, gently spiced and full of carrots. Excellent with cream cheese frosting and toasted nuts on the sides.

Makes two 8-inch layers | Serves 14 | Prep 30 min | Bake 30–35 min | 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 250 g (2 cups) all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp fine salt
- 2 tsp ground cinnamon
- ½ tsp ground nutmeg
- ½ tsp ground ginger
- 4 large eggs, room temperature
- 240 ml (1 cup) vegetable oil
- 200 g (1 cup, packed) light brown sugar
- 100 g (½ cup) granulated sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 300 g (3 cups) finely grated carrots, about 5 medium
- 115 g (1 cup) chopped walnuts or pecans, toasted (optional)

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line two 8-inch pans.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda, salt and spices.
3. In a large bowl, whisk the eggs, oil, both sugars and vanilla until smooth and slightly thickened.
4. Stir the dry ingredients into the wet until just combined, then fold in the carrots and nuts.
5. Divide between the pans and bake for 30–35 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool for 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack.

NOTES

- Grate carrots on the fine side of a box grater. Coarse shreds can make the layers fall apart when cut.

Eggless Vanilla Sponge

A soft, light vanilla cake made without eggs, using yogurt for lift and moisture. Perfect for egg-free celebrations.

Makes one 8-inch layer (double for two) | Serves 8 | Prep 15 min | Bake 30–35 min | 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 240 g (1 cup) plain yogurt, room temperature
- 150 g (¾ cup) granulated sugar
- ½ tsp baking soda
- 120 ml (½ cup) neutral oil
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 190 g (1½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 1¼ tsp baking powder
- ¼ tsp fine salt
- 80–120 ml (⅓–½ cup) milk, as needed

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line one 8-inch pan.
2. Whisk the yogurt and sugar until the sugar mostly dissolves. Stir in the baking soda and leave for 5 minutes until bubbly.
3. Whisk in the oil and vanilla.
4. Sift the flour, baking powder and salt over the bowl and fold gently. Add milk a little at a time until the batter falls slowly off the spatula in a thick ribbon.
5. Pour into the pan and bake for 30–35 minutes, until golden and springy.
6. Cool for 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack.

NOTES

- Make two batches separately rather than doubling in one bowl; the rise is more reliable.
- For an eggless chocolate version, replace 30 g of flour with 30 g cocoa powder.

Lemon Yogurt Drizzle Cake

A bright, tangy loaf with a crackly lemon syrup. The easiest cake in this book, and a great gift.

Makes one 9 × 5 inch loaf | Serves 10 | Prep 15 min | Bake 50–55 min | 350°F / 175°C

INGREDIENTS

- 190 g (1½ cups) all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp fine salt
- 200 g (1 cup) granulated sugar
- Finely grated zest of 2 lemons
- 240 g (1 cup) plain yogurt
- 3 large eggs
- 120 ml (½ cup) neutral oil
- ½ tsp vanilla extract

For the drizzle

- 80 ml (⅓ cup) fresh lemon juice
- 65 g (⅓ cup) granulated sugar

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease and line a 9 × 5 inch loaf pan.
2. Rub the lemon zest into the sugar with your fingers until fragrant.
3. Whisk the lemon sugar with the yogurt, eggs, oil and vanilla.
4. Whisk in the flour, baking powder and salt until just smooth.
5. Pour into the pan and bake for 50–55 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. While it bakes, heat the lemon juice and sugar until the sugar dissolves.
7. Poke the hot cake all over with a skewer and spoon the syrup over slowly. Cool completely in the pan.

Black Forest Cake

Chocolate sponge, cherries and whipped cream, finished with chocolate shavings. A celebration classic.

Serves 14 | Prep 45 min plus chilling | Uses the chocolate fudge cake

INGREDIENTS

- 1 Rich Chocolate Fudge Cake, two 8-inch layers, chilled
- 1 jar (680 g / 24 oz) pitted sour cherries in syrup
- 2 tbsp cherry liqueur or kirsch (optional)
- 1 batch Stabilised Whipped Cream, doubled
- 100 g dark chocolate, for shavings
- 12 fresh or maraschino cherries with stems, to decorate

METHOD

1. Drain the cherries, keeping the syrup. Mix 80 ml (⅓ cup) of syrup with the liqueur, if using.
2. Level both cake layers and slice each in half horizontally to make four thin layers.
3. Place one layer on a cake board. Brush generously with cherry syrup.
4. Spread with a 1 cm layer of whipped cream and scatter a third of the cherries over it.
5. Repeat with the next two layers. Top with the last layer, cut side down, and brush it with syrup.
6. Cover the top and sides with a thin crumb coat of cream and chill for 20 minutes.
7. Apply a final smooth coat of cream. Press chocolate shavings onto the sides.
8. Pipe 12 rosettes around the top edge with an open star tip and place a cherry on each. Chill for at least 2 hours before slicing.

NOTES

- Make shavings by dragging a vegetable peeler along a room-temperature block of chocolate.
- Keep this cake refrigerated and serve within 2 days.

CHAPTER

Frostings & fillings

The right frosting depends on the job: smooth sides, sharp piping, a light filling or a glossy drip. Each recipe below says what it's best for.

FROSTING	TEXTURE	BEST FOR	HOLDS IN WARM WEATHER
American buttercream	Sweet, dense	Beginners, piping, kids' cakes	Good
Swiss meringue buttercream	Silky, less sweet	Smooth finishes, elegant piping	Fair
Cream cheese frosting	Tangy, soft	Carrot and red velvet, rustic finishes	Poor, keep chilled
Chocolate ganache	Glossy or fudgy	Drips, glazes, under fondant	Good
Stabilised whipped cream	Light, airy	Black Forest, fruit cakes	Poor, keep chilled

American Buttercream

Quick, sweet and sturdy. The easiest frosting to learn piping with.

Makes about 4 cups | Fills and coats one 8-inch layer cake | Prep 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 226 g (1 cup) unsalted butter, softened
- 450 g (about 3¾ cups) icing sugar, sifted
- 3–4 tbsp whipping cream or milk
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- ⅛ tsp fine salt

METHOD

1. Beat the butter on medium-high for 3 minutes until very pale.
2. Add the icing sugar a cup at a time on low speed.
3. Add the vanilla, salt and 3 tbsp cream. Beat on medium-high for 3–4 minutes until light and fluffy.
4. Adjust: add more cream for softer frosting, or more icing sugar for stiffer piping.
5. For smooth sides, stir by hand with a spatula for 1–2 minutes to press out air bubbles.

NOTES

- Double the recipe if you plan to pipe borders and decorations as well.
- Stiff consistency for flowers and borders; medium for coating; soft for writing.

Swiss Meringue Buttercream

Silky, glossy and less sweet. The professional choice for smooth sides and sharp edges.

Makes about 5 cups | Prep 30 min | Needs a stand mixer and thermometer

INGREDIENTS

- 150 g egg whites (about 5 large eggs)
- 250 g (1¼ cups) granulated sugar
- 340 g (1½ cups) unsalted butter, cubed, soft but cool
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- ⅛ tsp fine salt

METHOD

1. Wipe the mixer bowl and whisk with a little vinegar to remove any grease.
2. Whisk the egg whites and sugar in the bowl over a pan of gently simmering water until the mixture reaches 71°C (160°F) and feels completely smooth between your fingers.
3. Move the bowl to the mixer and whip on high for 8–10 minutes until thick, glossy and the bowl feels cool.
4. Switch to the paddle. On medium speed, add the butter a few cubes at a time.
5. Keep beating. It may look curdled or soupy; this is normal. It will come together into a smooth buttercream within a few minutes.
6. Beat in the vanilla and salt.

NOTES

- Soupy and won't come together? Chill the bowl for 10 minutes, then beat again.
- Curdled and lumpy? It's too cold. Warm the outside of the bowl briefly with a hair dryer while beating.
- Keeps 1 week in the fridge. Bring to room temperature and re-beat before using.

Cream Cheese Frosting

Tangy and creamy, made to stay firm enough for layer cakes.

Makes about 3½ cups | Prep 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 225 g (8 oz) brick-style cream cheese, cold
- 115 g (½ cup) unsalted butter, softened
- 360–420 g (3–3½ cups) icing sugar, sifted
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of fine salt

METHOD

1. Beat the butter until smooth and creamy, about 2 minutes.
2. Add the cold cream cheese in pieces and beat just until combined. Don't over-beat or it will turn runny.
3. On low speed, add the icing sugar, vanilla and salt. Beat until smooth.
4. Chill for 20 minutes if it's too soft to spread.

NOTES

- Use the firm brick cheese, never spreadable tub cream cheese.
- Cakes with cream cheese frosting must be kept in the fridge.

Chocolate Ganache, Four Ways

Just chocolate and cream. Change the ratio and you change the job it does.

Prep 10 min | Ratios are chocolate to cream, by weight

INGREDIENTS

Choose your ratio

Drip (dark): 100 g dark chocolate : 100 g cream (1:1)

Drip (milk): 200 g milk chocolate : 100 g cream (2:1)

Drip (white): 300 g white chocolate : 100 g cream (3:1)

Frosting or under fondant (dark): 200 g dark chocolate : 100 g cream (2:1)

Truffles: 2:1, chilled until firm

METHOD

1. Chop the chocolate finely and place in a heatproof bowl.
2. Heat the cream until it just begins to steam and bubble at the edges.
3. Pour the cream over the chocolate and leave for 3 minutes without stirring.
4. Stir from the centre outwards until smooth and glossy.
5. For drips, cool to about 30–32°C (86–90°F): it should feel just slightly warm. For frosting, leave at room temperature until it's the texture of peanut butter, 1–3 hours.

NOTES

- Test a drip on the side of a cold glass before doing the cake.
- Too thick? Warm in 5-second bursts. Too thin? Wait a few more minutes.

Stabilised Whipped Cream

Light whipped cream that holds its shape for days in the fridge instead of weeping after a few hours.

Makes about 4 cups | Prep 15 min

INGREDIENTS

- 480 ml (2 cups) cold whipping cream, 35%
- 30 g (¼ cup) icing sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

Stabiliser, choose one

- 1 tsp unflavoured powdered gelatin + 4 tsp cold water
- or 115 g (½ cup) cold mascarpone

METHOD

1. Chill the bowl and whisk for 10 minutes.
2. If using gelatin: sprinkle it over the cold water, leave for 5 minutes, then microwave for 5–8 seconds until just melted. Let it cool slightly but stay liquid.
3. Whip the cream, icing sugar and vanilla (and mascarpone, if using) to soft peaks.
4. With the mixer running, pour in the melted gelatin in a thin stream.
5. Whip to medium-firm peaks. Stop as soon as it holds a sharp peak; over-whipped cream turns grainy.

Simple Syrup for Moist Layers

Brushed onto cake layers before filling, it keeps cakes moist for days and adds a hint of flavour.

Makes 1 cup · Prep 5 min

INGREDIENTS

- 100 g (½ cup) granulated sugar
- 120 ml (½ cup) water
- Flavouring: 1 tsp vanilla, a strip of lemon peel, or 1 tbsp liqueur

METHOD

1. Bring the sugar and water to a simmer, stirring until the sugar dissolves.
2. Add the flavouring and cool completely.
3. Brush 2–3 tbsp over each cooled cake layer before filling.

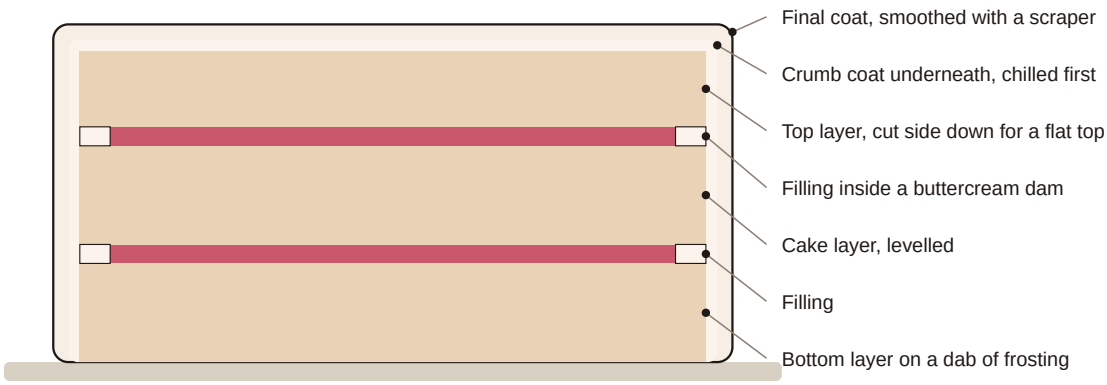
NOTES

- Keeps 2 weeks in a jar in the fridge.

CHAPTER

Decorating techniques

This chapter takes you from four plain cake layers to a smooth, professional-looking cake, then through the piping and finishing techniques used in the design projects.



A cross-section of a properly built layer cake.

Step 1: Level and tort

1. Chill the layers for at least 2 hours so they don't crumble.
2. Set a layer on the turntable. Hold a serrated knife level with the lowest point of the dome.
3. Turn the cake slowly while sawing gently, letting the turntable do the work, until the dome comes off.
4. To **tort** (split a layer in two), score a line all the way round at half the height, then cut along it.

Step 2: Fill and stack

1. Put a dab of frosting on the cake board and press the first layer on, cut side up.
2. Brush with syrup if using.
3. For soft fillings (curd, jam, fruit, whipped cream), **pipe a ring of stiff buttercream around the edge** first. This "dam" stops the filling squeezing out.
4. Spread the filling inside the dam, 6–10 mm thick.
5. Add the next layer and repeat. Place the final layer **cut side down**, so the top is perfectly flat.
6. Look at the cake from eye level and press gently to straighten it.

Step 3: Crumb coat

Spread a thin layer of frosting over the top and sides, just enough to trap loose crumbs and fill gaps. It doesn't need to look neat. **Chill for 20–30 minutes** until firm to the touch.

Step 4: The final coat

1. Pile a generous amount of frosting on top and spread it to the edges with an offset spatula, letting it overhang.
2. Cover the sides thickly using the spatula.
3. Hold the bench scraper **upright against the side at a 45° angle**, touching the board. Spin the turntable with your other hand in one smooth turn. Scrape excess back into the bowl.
4. Fill any gaps with more frosting and scrape again. Repeat until smooth.
5. A ridge of frosting will rise above the top edge. Chill for 10 minutes, then sweep it inwards with a clean offset spatula from the edge to the centre for a **sharp edge**.
6. For an extra-smooth finish, dip the scraper in hot water, dry it, and do one last pass.

Piping basics

- **Fill the bag** only two-thirds full, twist the top closed and hold the twist between thumb and forefinger. Squeeze from the top with your whole hand, not your fingertips.
- **Angle:** 90° (straight up) for rosettes, stars and dots; 45° for shells, borders and writing.
- **Pressure:** steady pressure for even shapes. To finish, stop squeezing, then pull away.
- **Practise** on parchment or an upside-down plate. Scrape it back into the bag and go again.

Six piping designs

DESIGN	TIP	HOW
Rosette	Open star 1M	Start in the centre, squeeze and circle outwards once, release and flick away
Star	1M or 2D	Hold at 90° just above the surface, squeeze, stop, lift
Shell border	1M or 21	At 45°, squeeze to build a mound, ease off while pulling forward to a tail; start the next shell on the tail
Drop flower	Closed star 2D	At 90°, squeeze while turning your wrist a quarter turn, stop and lift; add a dot in the centre
Ruffle	Petal #104	Wide end touching the cake, move the bag up and down in a tight zigzag as you travel
Writing	Round #2–#3, soft frosting	Touch, lift slightly, squeeze evenly, let the line fall into place; touch down to finish

Colouring buttercream

- Use **gel colours** and add them with a toothpick; colours deepen over 1–2 hours, so mix lighter than you want.
- For deep colours (red, black), start from chocolate buttercream for black, and make red the day before.
- For **ombré**, divide frosting into 3–4 bowls and add increasing amounts of the same colour.

Drips

1. Make drip ganache (chapter 3) and cool to 30–32°C (86–90°F).
2. **The cake must be cold**, straight from the fridge.
3. Put the ganache in a squeeze bottle or piping bag with a small cut. Test one drip at the back.
4. Squeeze gently at the top edge and let each drip run down. Vary the length by changing the pressure.
5. Fill in the top with the remaining ganache and smooth it with an offset spatula.

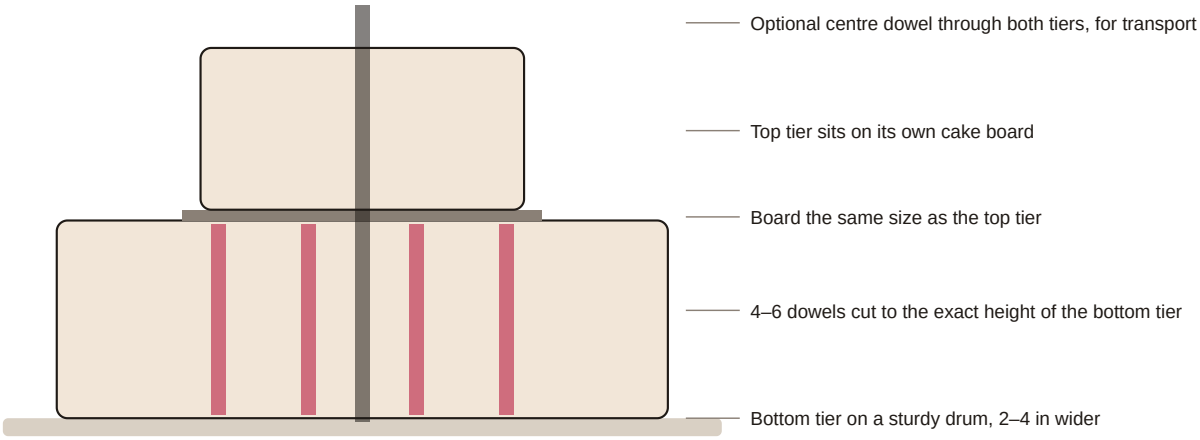
Naked and semi-naked

A **naked cake** shows the layers on the outside: fill and stack, then scrape the sides with only a whisper of frosting. **Semi-naked**: apply a thin coat and scrape most of it off so the cake shows through in places. Brush layers with syrup first; naked cakes dry out faster. Serve within a day.

Covering a cake with fondant

1. Give the cake a firm final coat of buttercream or 2:1 ganache and chill until firm.
2. Knead the fondant until soft and pliable. Use roughly **500 g for a 6-inch cake, 750 g for an 8-inch, and 1 kg for a 9–10-inch** cake that is 4 inches tall.
3. Dust the work surface lightly with cornflour and roll the fondant to about 4 mm thick, in a circle wider than the cake's diameter plus twice its height.
4. Lift it over your rolling pin and drape it over the cake.
5. Smooth the top first with a fondant smoother, then work down the sides, lifting and flaring the skirt to remove pleats. Never stretch it downwards.
6. Trim the base with a sharp knife or pizza cutter and polish with the smoother.

Stacking tiers



How a two-tier cake is supported. The dowels, not the cake, carry the weight of the top tier.

1. Put each tier on its own cake board the same size as the cake.
2. Press a dowel into the bottom tier, mark it level with the top, pull it out and cut 4–6 dowels to that height.
3. Insert them in a circle slightly smaller than the top tier's board.
4. Spread a little frosting where the top tier will sit, then centre the top tier on its board.
5. For transport, push a sharpened central dowel down through both tiers.

Serving sizes

ROUND CAKE, 4 IN TALL	PARTY SERVINGS (1.5 × 2 IN)	WEDDING SERVINGS (1 × 2 IN)
6-inch	12	12
8-inch	20	24
9-inch	24	32
10-inch	28	38
12-inch	40	56

Approximate guide. A 6-inch on an 8-inch two-tier cake serves about 32 party slices.

Storing and transporting

- Buttercream cakes keep at cool room temperature for a day, or 3–4 days in the fridge. Bring to room temperature for 1–2 hours before serving for the best flavour and texture.
- Cream cheese and whipped cream cakes must stay in the fridge.

- Transport in a box on a flat surface (car floor or boot, not on a seat), chilled, with non-slip matting underneath.

CHAPTER

Design projects

Four cakes that put every technique together. Each lists what to bake, what to make and the order to work in.

DESIGN PROJECT · BEGINNER

RECIPE 14

Ombré Rosette Cake

Rows of piped rosettes fading from deep to pale. Looks impressive and hides an imperfect finish.

Serves 14 | 2 hours decorating | Tip: open star 1M

INGREDIENTS

- 1 Classic Vanilla Butter Cake, two 8-inch layers, chilled
- 2 batches American Buttercream
- Pink or any gel colour
- 4 piping bags, 1 open star tip 1M

METHOD

1. Level the layers, tort them into four and stack with buttercream. Crumb coat and chill.
2. Spread a thin, smooth white coat over the cake and chill for 15 minutes.
3. Divide the remaining buttercream into four bowls. Leave one white and colour the others light, medium and dark.
4. Fill four bags with the tip moved between them, or use four tips.
5. Starting at the base with the darkest colour, pipe a row of rosettes around the cake, each touching the last.
6. Pipe the next row above with medium, then light, then white rosettes covering the top edge and spiralling to the centre.
7. Chill for 30 minutes to set before moving or slicing.

NOTES

- Work on a turntable and pipe each row in one go so the spacing stays even.

Birthday Drip Cake

Smooth sides, a chocolate drip and a crown of sweets and rosettes. The modern birthday classic.

Serves 16 | 3 hours decorating | Tips: 1M, round #12

INGREDIENTS

- 1 Rich Chocolate Fudge Cake, two 8-inch layers, chilled
- 1 batch Swiss Meringue Buttercream (or 2 batches American)
- 1 batch dark drip ganache (1:1)
- Gel colour of your choice
- Toppings: chocolate bars, macarons, sprinkles, a cake topper

METHOD

1. Level, tort and stack the layers with buttercream. Crumb coat and chill for 30 minutes.
2. Colour most of the remaining buttercream. Apply the final coat, scraping smooth with a sharp top edge. Chill for at least 1 hour.
3. Press sprinkles onto the bottom 2 cm of the sides, if using.
4. Cool the ganache to 30–32°C and test one drip at the back. Apply drips all round, then fill the top.
5. Chill for 15 minutes to set the drip.
6. Pipe 8–10 rosettes in a crescent on one side of the top. Arrange chocolates, macarons and the topper in and around them.

NOTES

- Arrange toppings in odd numbers and keep them to one side of the top for a modern look.

Semi-Naked Floral Cake

Rustic, elegant and quick. Ideal for showers, small weddings and anyone who doesn't love heavy frosting.

Serves 14 | 1.5 hours decorating | No piping needed

INGREDIENTS

- 1 Lemon Yogurt Drizzle batter baked as two 8-inch layers, or Classic Vanilla
- 1 batch Swiss Meringue Buttercream or Cream Cheese Frosting
- 1 jar lemon curd or 250 g fresh berries
- Fresh edible flowers or herbs, washed and dried; berries to garnish
- Small pieces of floral tape and cling film for any non-edible stems

METHOD

1. Brush layers with lemon syrup. Stack with a buttercream dam and a layer of curd or berries inside each.
2. Apply a thin coat all over.
3. Holding the scraper at 45°, scrape off most of the frosting so the cake shows through, leaving a frosted haze. Chill.
4. Wrap the stems of any flowers in floral tape and cling film so they never touch the cake directly.
5. Arrange flowers and berries in a cluster sweeping down one side and across the top.

NOTES

- Only use flowers sold as edible or grown without sprays. Many florist flowers are treated with chemicals and some are toxic.

Two-Tier Celebration Cake

A 6-inch tier on an 8-inch tier, smooth white finish and a simple piped detail.
The plan for your first tiered cake.

Serves about 32 | Plan over 3 days | Tips: round #3, 2D

INGREDIENTS

- 1 batch Classic Vanilla Butter Cake (two 8-inch layers)
- 1 batch Classic Vanilla Butter Cake baked in three 6-inch pans (use 2 layers, enjoy the third)
- 2 batches Swiss Meringue Buttercream
- One 8-inch and one 6-inch cake board, plus a 10-inch drum
- 5 dowels or wide bubble-tea straws
- Fresh flowers or sugar flowers to finish

METHOD

1. **Day 1:** bake all layers, cool, wrap and chill. Make the buttercream and refrigerate.
2. **Day 2:** bring the buttercream to room temperature and re-beat. Level, fill and crumb coat both tiers on their own boards. Chill.
3. **Day 2:** apply final coats with sharp edges. Chill overnight.
4. **Day 3:** fix the 8-inch tier to the drum with buttercream. Insert dowels cut to its exact height (see Stacking tiers).
5. Lift the 6-inch tier with an offset spatula under the board and centre it on top.
6. Pipe a small shell or bead border round the base of each tier to hide the joins.
7. Add the flowers in a cascade from the top tier down one side. Keep chilled until 1–2 hours before serving.

NOTES

- Write a timeline and stick to it. Rushing the chilling steps is the main cause of leaning tiers.

CHAPTER

Planning a celebration cake

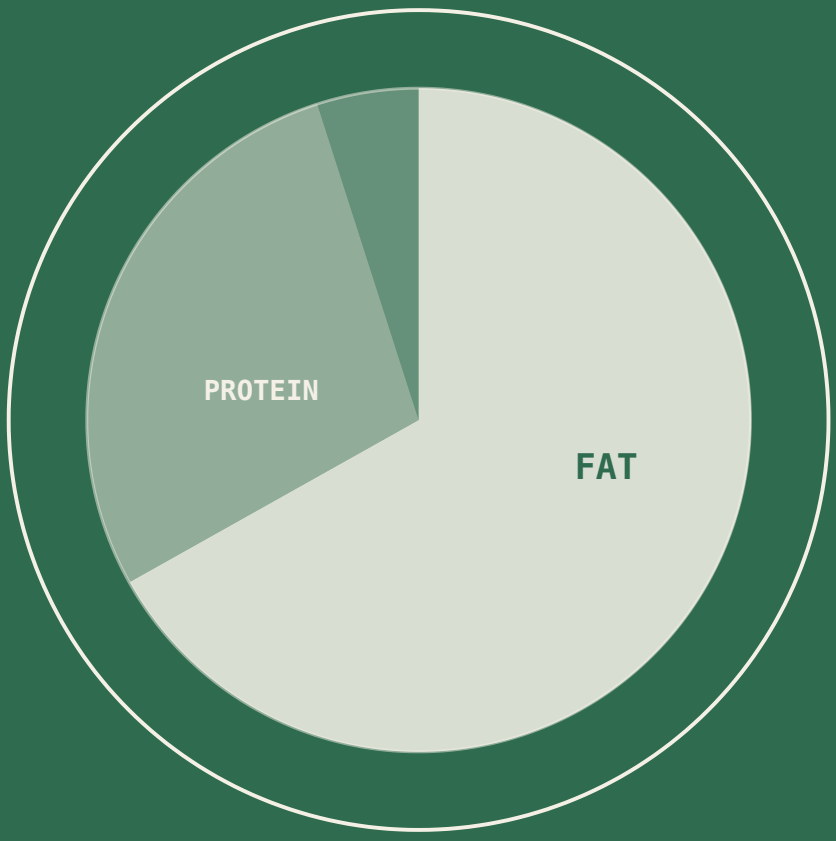
A simple timeline

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
1 week before	Confirm size, flavour, design and dietary needs. Order or buy toppers and tools
3 days before	Shop for ingredients. Make syrup and any sugar decorations
2 days before	Bake layers, cool, wrap and chill. Make frosting
1 day before	Level, fill, crumb coat, final coat. Chill overnight
The day	Drips, piping, flowers and toppings. Box and transport chilled

Flavour pairings that work

CAKE	FILLING	FROSTING
Vanilla	Raspberry jam	Vanilla Swiss meringue
Chocolate	Salted caramel	Chocolate ganache
Red velvet	Cream cheese	Cream cheese
Carrot	Toasted pecans	Cream cheese with cinnamon
Lemon	Lemon curd	Vanilla buttercream
Eggless vanilla	Mango purée	Whipped cream
Chocolate	Cherries	Whipped cream (Black Forest)

Allergy note: always ask about allergies and label celebration cakes for guests: wheat, eggs, milk, tree nuts and peanuts are common in decorated cakes, and many sprinkles and decorations contain several allergens.



The Recipe Vault · Vol. 02

Keto Kitchen

Low-carb cooking, explained

SchoolAura

SCHOOLAURA.COM · FOD 110

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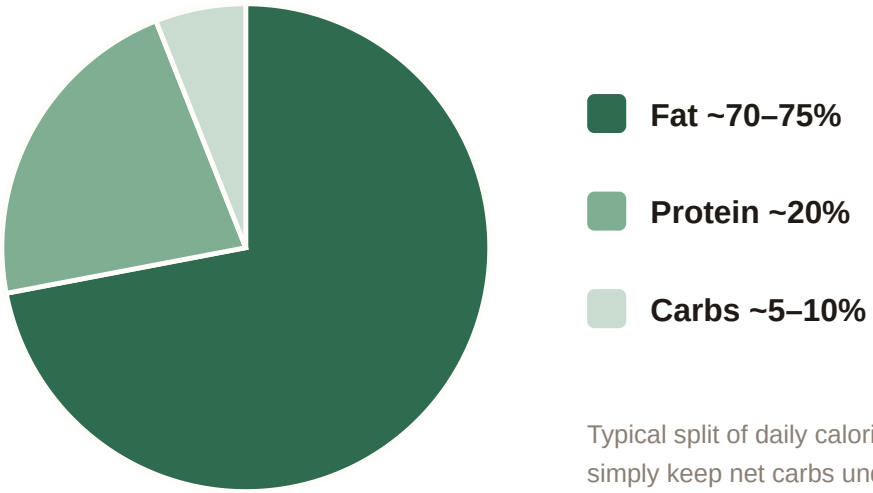
Start here

Please read first. This book is general information about a way of eating, not medical advice. Talk to your doctor before starting a ketogenic diet, especially if you take medication for diabetes or blood pressure, are pregnant or breastfeeding, have kidney, liver, pancreas or gallbladder conditions, or have a history of disordered eating. Keto isn't right for everyone, and that's fine.

What keto is

A **ketogenic (keto) diet** is a very low-carbohydrate, higher-fat way of eating. When you eat very few carbs, your body runs low on its usual fuel (glucose) and starts burning more fat, producing **ketones** that your brain and muscles can use. This state is called **ketosis**.

Most people eat keto by keeping **net carbs between 20 and 50 g a day**, eating a moderate amount of protein, and getting the rest of their energy from fats.



A common daily calorie split on keto. You don't need to track percentages: counting net carbs is enough for most people.

Net carbs

Net carbs = total carbohydrates − fibre. Fibre isn't digested into sugar, so it's subtracted. Many low-carb sweeteners such as **erythritol** and **allulose** are also usually subtracted, because they have little effect on blood sugar. Other sugar alcohols like maltitol raise blood sugar more, so count about half of them.

In Canada, the Nutrition Facts table lists carbohydrate, fibre and sugars. Subtract the fibre line from the carbohydrate line.

> **Example:** a serving of almond flour lists 6 g carbohydrate and 3 g fibre. Net carbs = 6 − 3 = **3 g**.

How much protein?

Enough to keep you full and protect your muscles: roughly a **palm-sized portion at each meal**. You don't need to eat huge amounts of protein, and you don't need to fear it.

The first two weeks: keto flu

When you cut carbs, your body releases water and salts. In the first days, some people feel tired, foggy, headachy or irritable. This is often called **keto flu**, and it's mostly caused by low fluids and electrolytes.

To feel better:

- **Drink more water** than usual.
- **Salt your food** and consider a cup of broth daily.
- Eat **potassium-rich** keto foods: avocado, spinach, mushrooms, salmon.
- **Magnesium** from nuts, seeds, leafy greens and dark chocolate.
- Go easy on hard exercise for the first week.

If symptoms are severe or don't improve within a couple of weeks, stop and speak to your doctor.

Recipe numbers in this book

Net carbs per serving are **estimates** calculated from standard nutrition data. Brands vary, so check your labels if you track closely.

CHAPTER

What to eat

Eat freely

GROUP	EXAMPLES
Meat and poultry	Chicken thighs, beef, lamb, pork, turkey
Fish and seafood	Salmon, sardines, trout, tuna, shrimp, mussels
Eggs	Any style
Low-carb vegetables	Spinach, lettuce, kale, zucchini, cauliflower, broccoli, cabbage, asparagus, green beans, mushrooms, cucumber, peppers
Healthy fats	Olive oil, avocado oil, butter, ghee, coconut oil
Full-fat dairy	Cheese, paneer, cream, sour cream, plain Greek yogurt (small portions)

In moderation

GROUP	WATCH OUT FOR
Nuts and seeds	Easy to overeat. Almonds, walnuts, pecans, macadamias, chia and flax are lowest in net carbs
Berries	Raspberries and blackberries are lowest. About ½ cup at a time
Onions, garlic, tomatoes	Use as flavouring rather than as the main ingredient
Dark chocolate (85%+)	A square or two
Alcohol	Dry wine and plain spirits have few carbs, but alcohol slows fat burning and lowers willpower

Avoid or keep very small

GROUP	EXAMPLES
Sugar	Sugar, honey, maple syrup, sweets, regular soft drinks, juice
Grains and starches	Bread, pasta, rice, oats, cereal, crackers, flour tortillas
Starchy vegetables	Potatoes, sweet potatoes, corn, peas
Legumes	Beans, lentils, chickpeas (high in carbs, though healthy in other diets)
Most fruit	Bananas, grapes, mango, dried fruit
"Low-fat" products	Often have added sugar to replace the fat

Easy swaps

INSTEAD OF	TRY
Rice	Cauliflower rice
Pasta	Zucchini noodles, shirataki noodles
Tortillas and buns	Large lettuce leaves
Mashed potato	Mashed cauliflower with butter
Flour for baking	Almond flour, coconut flour
Sugar	Erythritol, monk fruit or allulose blends
Crisps	Cheese crisps, pork rinds, nuts

A sample week

Snacks if needed: cheese crisps, a fat bomb, olives, a handful of almonds.

DAY	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER
Mon	Spinach & feta egg muffins	Chicken cobb salad	Garlic butter salmon
Tue	Coconut chia pudding	Tuna-stuffed avocados	Keto butter chicken
Wed	Egg muffins (batch)	Leftover butter chicken	Lettuce-wrap beef tacos
Thu	Cream cheese pancakes	Zucchini noodles with pesto	Creamy Tuscan chicken
Fri	Chia pudding (batch)	Leftover Tuscan chicken	Paneer tikka skewers
Sat	Eggs, bacon, avocado	Cauliflower fried rice	Garlic butter salmon
Sun	Cream cheese pancakes	Cobb salad	Butter chicken

CHAPTER

Breakfast

BREAKFAST · BATCH COOK

RECIPE 01

Spinach & Feta Egg Muffins

Make twelve on Sunday and breakfast is ready all week. Reheat in 30 seconds or eat cold.

Makes 12 | Serves 4 | Prep 10 min | Bake 20 min | ≈ 3 g net carbs per 3 muffins

INGREDIENTS

- 10 large eggs
- 60 ml (¼ cup) whipping cream
- 60 g (2 cups) baby spinach, chopped
- 100 g feta, crumbled
- ½ red pepper, finely diced
- ½ tsp salt, ¼ tsp black pepper
- Butter or oil, for the tin

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C). Grease a 12-cup muffin tin well, or use silicone cups.
2. Whisk the eggs, cream, salt and pepper in a large jug.
3. Divide the spinach, pepper and feta between the cups.
4. Pour the egg mixture over, filling each cup about three-quarters full.
5. Bake for 18–22 minutes, until puffed and set in the middle.
6. Cool for 5 minutes before removing. Store in the fridge for up to 4 days.

NOTES

- Swap in cooked bacon, mushrooms, cheddar or chopped green onion.

Coconut Chia Pudding

Creamy, filling and ready when you wake up. Make two jars at once.

Serves 2 | Prep 5 min | Chill 4 hours or overnight | ≈ 4 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 3 tbsp (36 g) chia seeds
- 120 ml (½ cup) full-fat canned coconut milk
- 120 ml (½ cup) water or unsweetened almond milk
- ½ tsp vanilla extract
- Keto sweetener to taste (about 1–2 tsp)
- 30 g (¼ cup) raspberries, to serve

METHOD

1. Stir the chia, coconut milk, water, vanilla and sweetener together in a jar.
2. Wait 5 minutes and stir again, breaking up any clumps.
3. Cover and refrigerate for at least 4 hours or overnight.
4. Stir, then top with raspberries.

NOTES

- Add 1 tbsp cocoa powder for a chocolate version (+1 g net carbs).

Cream Cheese Pancakes

Soft, slightly sweet pancakes with a crêpe-like texture. Great with butter and a few berries.

Serves 2 (6 small pancakes) | Prep 5 min | Cook 10 min | ≈ 4 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 2 large eggs
- 60 g (2 oz) cream cheese, softened
- 30 g (⅓ cup) almond flour
- ½ tsp baking powder
- Pinch of cinnamon and salt
- Butter, for the pan

METHOD

1. Blend or whisk all the ingredients until completely smooth. Rest for 2 minutes.
2. Heat a non-stick pan over medium-low heat and add a little butter.
3. Pour in 3 tbsp of batter per pancake. Cook for 2 minutes until bubbles appear and the edges set.
4. Flip carefully and cook for 1 minute more.

NOTES

- Keep the heat low: these brown quickly and are delicate to flip.

CHAPTER

Lunch

LUNCH RECIPE 04

Chicken Cobb Salad

A big, satisfying salad with every component you want: crisp bacon, creamy avocado, eggs and blue cheese.

Serves 2 | Prep 15 min | ≈ 5 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 1 head romaine, chopped (about 4 cups)
- 250 g cooked chicken, sliced
- 2 hard-boiled eggs, quartered
- 4 slices bacon, cooked and crumbled
- 1 avocado, diced
- 6 cherry tomatoes, halved
- 40 g blue cheese, crumbled

Dressing

- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tbsp red wine vinegar
- 1 tsp Dijon mustard
- Salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Shake the dressing ingredients together in a jar.
2. Lay the romaine on two plates.
3. Arrange the chicken, eggs, bacon, avocado, tomatoes and cheese in rows on top.
4. Drizzle with dressing just before eating.

NOTES

- Pack the dressing separately if taking this to work.

Cauliflower Fried Rice with Shrimp

All the flavour of takeout fried rice for a fraction of the carbs.

Serves 2 | Prep 10 min | Cook 10 min | ≈ 9 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 400 g riced cauliflower, fresh or frozen
- 250 g raw shrimp, peeled
- 2 large eggs, beaten
- 2 green onions, sliced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp grated ginger
- 2 tbsp tamari or soy sauce
- 1 tbsp toasted sesame oil
- 1 tbsp avocado oil

METHOD

1. Heat the avocado oil in a large pan or wok over high heat. Cook the shrimp for 2 minutes until pink. Remove.
2. Pour in the eggs, scramble quickly and push to one side.
3. Add the garlic, ginger and white parts of the green onions. Stir for 30 seconds.
4. Add the cauliflower and stir-fry for 4–5 minutes until tender and slightly toasted.
5. Return the shrimp, add the tamari and sesame oil, and toss. Top with green onion tops.

NOTES

- If using frozen cauliflower, cook it first until the water evaporates, so the rice isn't soggy.

Zucchini Noodles with Pesto & Chicken

Fresh and fast. Don't overcook the noodles; they should keep a little bite.

Serves 2 | Prep 10 min | Cook 5 min | ≈ 7 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 2 medium zucchini, spiralised
- 250 g cooked chicken, sliced
- 4 tbsp basil pesto
- 6 cherry tomatoes, halved
- 20 g parmesan, shaved
- 1 tbsp olive oil, salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Heat the oil in a large pan over medium-high heat.
2. Add the zucchini noodles and toss for 1–2 minutes, just until warm.
3. Take the pan off the heat and stir in the pesto and chicken.
4. Serve topped with tomatoes and parmesan.

NOTES

- Check pesto labels: some add sugar or cashews. Homemade or Italian-style is lowest in carbs.

Tuna-Stuffed Avocados

Five minutes, no cooking, and very filling.

Serves 2 | Prep 5 min | ≈ 3 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 1 large ripe avocado
- 1 can (140 g drained) tuna
- 2 tbsp mayonnaise
- 1 celery stalk, finely diced
- 1 tbsp finely chopped red onion
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- Salt, pepper, paprika

METHOD

1. Mix the tuna, mayonnaise, celery, onion and lemon juice. Season well.
2. Halve the avocado, remove the stone and scoop out a little extra flesh to widen the hollow. Chop it into the tuna.
3. Pile the tuna into the avocado halves and sprinkle with paprika.

CHAPTER

Dinner

DINNER · FAMILY FAVOURITE

RECIPE 08

Keto Butter Chicken

Rich, mildly spiced and creamy. Serve with cauliflower rice or a crisp salad.

Serves 4 | Prep 15 min plus 30 min marinating | Cook 30 min

≈ 7 g net carbs per serving (≈ 11 g with cauliflower rice)

INGREDIENTS

700 g boneless chicken thighs, cut into bite-size pieces

Marinade

60 g (¼ cup) full-fat plain Greek yogurt

1 tbsp lemon juice

2 tsp garam masala

1 tsp turmeric

1 tsp Kashmiri chilli powder (or ½ tsp paprika + pinch of cayenne)

1 tsp salt

Sauce

3 tbsp butter

1 small onion, finely chopped

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 tbsp grated ginger

200 g (¾ cup) tomato passata

1 tsp garam masala, ½ tsp cumin, 1 tsp paprika

1 tsp dried fenugreek leaves (kasuri methi), optional

150 ml (⅔ cup) whipping cream

METHOD

1. Mix the chicken with the marinade ingredients and leave for at least 30 minutes (or overnight in the fridge).
2. Melt 1 tbsp butter in a large pan over medium-high heat. Brown the chicken in batches, 3–4 minutes per batch. It doesn't need to be cooked through. Set aside.
3. Melt the rest of the butter. Cook the onion for 6–8 minutes until soft and golden.
4. Add the garlic and ginger for 1 minute, then the spices for 30 seconds.
5. Stir in the passata and simmer for 8 minutes until thick.
6. Add the cream, fenugreek and chicken. Simmer for 10 minutes until the chicken is cooked through (74°C / 165°F).
7. Taste for salt and serve with coriander.

NOTES

- Blend the sauce before adding the chicken for a restaurant-smooth texture.

- Fresh coriander, to serve

Garlic Butter Salmon with Asparagus

Twenty minutes on one tray. Lemon, garlic and butter do all the work.

Serves 2 | Prep 5 min | Cook 15 min | ≈ 5 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 2 salmon fillets (about 300 g total)
- 300 g asparagus, woody ends snapped off
- 3 tbsp butter, melted
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- ½ lemon, sliced, plus juice of the other half
- Salt, pepper, chopped parsley

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 400°F (200°C) and line a tray with parchment.
2. Toss the asparagus with half the melted butter, salt and pepper and spread on the tray.
3. Place the salmon in the middle. Mix the remaining butter with the garlic and lemon juice and spoon over the fish. Top with lemon slices.
4. Roast for 12–15 minutes, until the salmon flakes easily.
5. Scatter with parsley and spoon the pan juices over.

Lettuce-Wrap Beef Tacos

All the fun of taco night. Set everything out and let everyone build their own.

Serves 4 | Prep 15 min | Cook 10 min | ≈ 5 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 500 g lean ground beef
- 60 ml (¼ cup) water
- 1 head butter lettuce, leaves separated
- 100 g cheddar, grated
- 120 g (½ cup) sour cream
- 1 avocado, sliced
- 80 g (⅓ cup) salsa, no sugar added
- Lime wedges and coriander

Taco seasoning

- 2 tsp chilli powder, 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp paprika
- ½ tsp each garlic powder, onion powder, dried oregano
- ¾ tsp salt

METHOD

1. Brown the beef in a large pan over medium-high heat, breaking it up, for 6–8 minutes.
2. Pour off excess fat. Add the seasoning and water and simmer for 2–3 minutes until saucy.
3. Spoon into lettuce leaves and top with cheese, sour cream, avocado and salsa.

NOTES

- Shop-bought taco mixes often contain sugar and starch. The homemade blend takes one minute.

Paneer Tikka Skewers

Smoky, spiced paneer and peppers from the oven or grill. A vegetarian keto favourite.

Serves 3 | Prep 15 min plus 30 min marinating | Cook 15 min | ≈ 8 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 400 g paneer, cut into 2.5 cm cubes
- 1 green pepper, cut into squares
- ½ red onion, cut into chunks

Marinade

- 120 g (½ cup) full-fat Greek yogurt
- 1 tbsp lemon juice
- 1 tbsp oil
- 2 tsp ginger-garlic paste
- 1 tsp Kashmiri chilli powder, 1 tsp garam masala
- ½ tsp turmeric, ½ tsp cumin, 1 tsp dried fenugreek leaves
- ¾ tsp salt

METHOD

1. Whisk the marinade, add the paneer and vegetables and coat gently. Leave for 30 minutes.
2. If using wooden skewers, soak them in water while the paneer marinates.
3. Heat the oven to 450°F (230°C) or a grill to high. Thread paneer and vegetables onto skewers.
4. Cook for 12–15 minutes, turning once, until charred at the edges.
5. Serve with lemon wedges and a cucumber-mint yogurt.

Creamy Tuscan Chicken

Golden chicken in a garlicky cream sauce with spinach and sun-dried tomatoes.

Serves 4 | Prep 10 min | Cook 25 min | ≈ 5 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 700 g chicken breasts, halved horizontally into thin cutlets
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 40 g sun-dried tomatoes in oil, chopped
- 240 ml (1 cup) whipping cream
- 60 g parmesan, grated
- 60 g (2 cups) baby spinach
- 1 tsp Italian seasoning, salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Season the chicken with salt, pepper and Italian seasoning.
2. Heat the oil in a large pan over medium-high heat and cook the chicken 4–5 minutes per side until golden and cooked through. Set aside.
3. Lower the heat. Add the garlic and sun-dried tomatoes and cook for 1 minute.
4. Pour in the cream and simmer for 3 minutes. Stir in the parmesan until melted.
5. Add the spinach and stir until wilted. Return the chicken and spoon the sauce over.

CHAPTER

Snacks & sweets

SNACK RECIPE 13

Crispy Cheese Crisps

One ingredient, crunchy like a cracker. Great for dips or on their own.

Serves 2 (about 12 crisps) · Prep 2 min · Bake 6 min · ≈ 1 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 100 g finely grated parmesan or aged cheddar
- Optional: pinch of chilli flakes, everything bagel seasoning or dried herbs

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 400°F (200°C) and line a tray with parchment.
2. Place tablespoon mounds of cheese on the tray, 5 cm apart, and flatten slightly. Add any seasoning.
3. Bake for 5–7 minutes until golden at the edges.
4. Cool on the tray for 5 minutes; they crisp as they cool.

Chocolate Almond Fat Bombs

Rich, bite-sized chocolate treats to stop sweet cravings.

Makes 12 | Prep 10 min | Freeze 30 min | ≈ 1 g net carbs each

INGREDIENTS

- 120 g (½ cup) coconut oil, softened
- 125 g (½ cup) unsweetened almond butter
- 3 tbsp (15 g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 2–3 tbsp powdered keto sweetener, to taste
- ½ tsp vanilla extract, pinch of flaky salt

METHOD

1. Stir everything together until smooth. Warm gently if the coconut oil is firm.
2. Spoon into 12 silicone moulds or a lined mini muffin tin.
3. Freeze for 30 minutes until firm. Store in the fridge or freezer.

90-Second Mug Bread

A quick slice of bread for sandwiches or toast. Cooks in the microwave.

Makes 1 roll (2 slices) · Prep 2 min · Cook 90 sec · ≈ 2.5 g net carbs

INGREDIENTS

- 3 tbsp (21 g) almond flour
- 1 large egg
- 1 tbsp butter, melted
- ½ tsp baking powder
- Pinch of salt

METHOD

1. Mix everything in a greased, straight-sided mug or ramekin until smooth.
2. Microwave on high for 90 seconds, until set and springy.
3. Turn out, cool for 2 minutes and slice in half. Toast in a pan with butter for the best texture.

Chocolate Avocado Mousse

Silky and rich. The avocado makes it creamy; you won't taste it.

Serves 4 | Prep 10 min | Chill 30 min | ≈ 3 g net carbs per serving

INGREDIENTS

- 2 ripe avocados
- 4 tbsp (20 g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 120 ml (½ cup) whipping cream or coconut milk
- 3–4 tbsp powdered keto sweetener, to taste
- 1 tsp vanilla extract, pinch of salt

METHOD

1. Blend everything in a food processor until completely smooth, scraping the sides.
2. Taste and add more sweetener or cocoa if needed.
3. Spoon into four small glasses and chill for 30 minutes.
4. Top with a few raspberries or whipped cream.

Almond Flour Shortbread

Buttery, crumbly cookies with only four main ingredients.

Makes 16 · Prep 15 min · Bake 10–12 min · ≈ 1.5 g net carbs each

INGREDIENTS

- 200 g (2 cups) almond flour
- 85 g (6 tbsp) butter, softened
- 65 g (⅓ cup) granulated keto sweetener
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt

METHOD

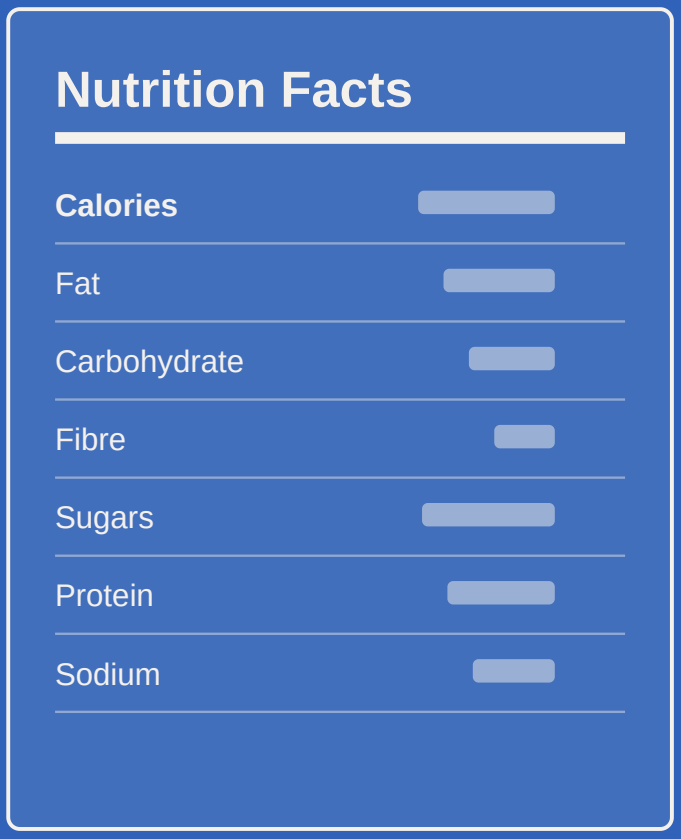
1. Heat the oven to 350°F (175°C) and line a tray with parchment.
2. Beat the butter and sweetener until creamy, then mix in the vanilla, salt and almond flour to form a dough.
3. Roll into 16 balls and flatten to 1 cm thick with a fork.
4. Bake for 10–12 minutes until golden at the edges.
5. Cool completely on the tray; they firm up as they cool.

CHAPTER

Shopping list

A starter shop for the sample week, for one or two people. Adjust quantities to your household.

- **Protein:** chicken thighs (700 g), chicken breasts (700 g), cooked chicken (500 g), salmon fillets (4), ground beef (500 g), raw shrimp (250 g), canned tuna (2), bacon, 2 dozen eggs, paneer (400 g)
- **Dairy:** butter, whipping cream (500 ml), cream cheese, feta, parmesan, cheddar, blue cheese, sour cream, full-fat Greek yogurt
- **Vegetables:** baby spinach, romaine, butter lettuce, zucchini (2), riced cauliflower (800 g), asparagus, peppers, celery, cherry tomatoes, green onions, onion, garlic, ginger, lemons, limes, coriander, parsley
- **Fruit:** avocados (6), raspberries
- **Pantry:** olive oil, avocado oil, coconut oil, sesame oil, tamari, Dijon mustard, red wine vinegar, mayonnaise, pesto, tomato passata, sun-dried tomatoes, salsa
- **Baking and snacks:** almond flour, chia seeds, almond butter, cocoa powder, keto sweetener, baking powder, canned coconut milk, almonds
- **Spices:** garam masala, turmeric, Kashmiri chilli, cumin, paprika, chilli powder, Italian seasoning, dried fenugreek, cinnamon



The Recipe Vault · Vol. 03

Know Your Food

Labels, nutrients, portions, safety

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CHAPTER

Energy and calories

Food gives your body energy, measured in **calories** (strictly, kilocalories, written kcal or Cal). Every food label in Canada and the US shows calories per serving.

Where calories come from

NUTRIENT	CALORIES PER GRAM
Carbohydrate	4
Protein	4
Fat	9
Alcohol	7
Fibre	about 2 (partly digested)

That's why a tablespoon of oil (about 14 g of fat) has around 120 calories, while a whole cup of broccoli has about 30.

How much energy do you need?

It depends on your age, size, sex and how active you are. Many adults need somewhere between 1,800 and 3,000 calories a day. The **% Daily Value** on Canadian labels is based on a 2,000-calorie diet, as a reference point, not a target for everyone.

You don't need to count calories to eat well. Building balanced meals (chapter 4) and noticing hunger and fullness works for most people. Counting can help if you have a specific goal; if it makes you anxious about food, it isn't worth it.

Calories aren't the whole story

A 200-calorie snack of nuts and a 200-calorie soft drink have the same energy but very different effects. The nuts bring protein, fibre, healthy fats and minerals that keep you full. The soft drink brings sugar and little else. **What a food contains** matters as much as how much energy it has.

CHAPTER

The big three: macronutrients

Protein

Protein builds and repairs muscles, skin, hair, enzymes and hormones. It also keeps you full longer than carbs or fat.

- **Sources:** meat, poultry, fish, eggs, dairy, tofu, tempeh, paneer, beans, lentils, chickpeas, nuts and seeds.
- **How much:** a common guide for healthy adults is about **0.8 g per kg of body weight per day** (about 56 g for a 70 kg adult). Older adults, active people and those recovering from illness often benefit from more.
- **Easy target:** include a palm-sized portion of protein at each meal.

Carbohydrates

Carbs are your body's preferred quick fuel, especially for the brain and for exercise.

- **Whole carbohydrates** come with fibre, vitamins and minerals: whole grains, oats, brown rice, beans, lentils, fruit, vegetables.
- **Refined carbohydrates** have had much of that removed: white bread, pastries, sweets, sugary drinks.
- **Sugars** occur naturally in fruit and milk, and are added to many packaged foods. Health Canada and many health groups advise limiting added and "free" sugars.

Fibre

Fibre is a carbohydrate you don't digest. It keeps your gut healthy, helps with regularity, slows the rise in blood sugar after meals and helps you feel full.

Health Canada's recommended intake is about **25 g a day for adult women and 38 g for adult men**. Most people eat far less.

Easy ways to get more: oats for breakfast, beans or lentils in soups and salads, whole-grain bread, fruit with the skin on, a handful of nuts, an extra vegetable at dinner.

Fats

Fat carries flavour, helps you absorb vitamins A, D, E and K, and is essential for your brain and cells.

TYPE	FOUND IN	CHOOSE
Unsaturated (mono and poly)	Olive oil, canola oil, avocado, nuts, seeds, fatty fish	**Most of the time**
Omega-3 (a polyunsaturated fat)	Salmon, sardines, trout, walnuts, chia, flax	**Often**
Saturated	Butter, cheese, fatty meat, coconut oil, palm oil	**In smaller amounts**
Trans	Industrially produced partially hydrogenated oils	**Avoid.** Canada banned them in foods in 2018

CHAPTER

Vitamins, minerals and water

Micronutrients are needed in small amounts, but you can't live without them. A varied diet with plenty of colour covers most needs.

NUTRIENT	WHAT IT DOES	GOOD SOURCES
Vitamin A	Vision, immunity, skin	Carrots, sweet potato, spinach, eggs, milk
B vitamins (B6, B12, folate)	Energy, red blood cells, nerves	Whole grains, meat, eggs, legumes, leafy greens. **B12 only in animal foods or fortified foods**
Vitamin C	Immunity, healing, iron absorption	Peppers, citrus, strawberries, broccoli, kiwi
Vitamin D	Bones, immunity	Fatty fish, fortified milk and plant drinks, egg yolks. Hard to get from sun in a Canadian winter
Vitamin K	Blood clotting, bones	Leafy greens, broccoli, Brussels sprouts
Calcium	Bones, teeth, muscles	Milk, yogurt, cheese, fortified plant drinks, tofu made with calcium, canned salmon with bones
Iron	Carries oxygen in the blood	Red meat, chicken, beans, lentils, tofu, fortified cereals. Eat with vitamin C for better absorption
Potassium	Heart, muscles, blood pressure	Potatoes, bananas, beans, yogurt, leafy greens
Magnesium	Muscles, nerves, energy	Nuts, seeds, whole grains, leafy greens, dark chocolate
Zinc	Immunity, healing	Meat, shellfish, legumes, seeds, dairy
Iodine	Thyroid hormones	Iodized salt, dairy, seafood, eggs
Sodium	Fluid balance	Salt, and most packaged and restaurant food. **Most people eat too much**

About supplements: most healthy people can get what they need from food. Some groups may need supplements, for example vitamin D in winter, folic acid before and during pregnancy, and B12 for vegans. Ask a doctor or pharmacist before starting any supplement.

Water

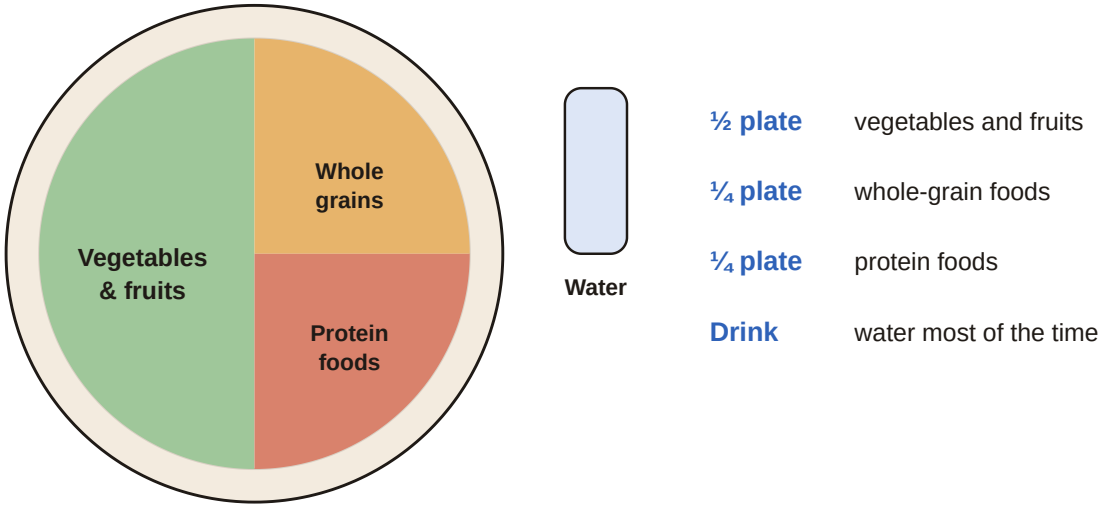
Your body is about 60% water. Needs vary, but a common guide is around **2–3 litres of fluids a day** for adults, including water from food. Drink more in hot weather and when exercising.

- Make **water your drink of choice**. Plain milk and unsweetened plant drinks are good too.
- Pale yellow urine is a simple sign you're drinking enough.
- Juice, soft drinks and many coffee-shop drinks contain a lot of sugar.

CHAPTER

Building a balanced plate

Canada's Food Guide suggests a simple picture for most meals:



½ plate	vegetables and fruits
¼ plate	whole-grain foods
¼ plate	protein foods
Drink	water most of the time

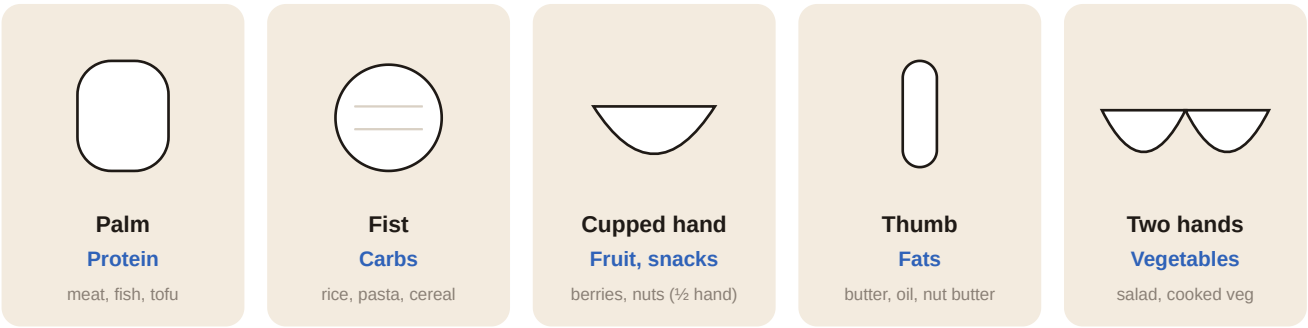
The balanced plate, based on Canada's Food Guide.

- **Half the plate:** vegetables and fruits, in a range of colours.
- **A quarter:** whole-grain foods such as brown rice, whole-wheat pasta, oats, quinoa or whole-grain bread.
- **A quarter:** protein foods, choosing plant-based proteins more often.
- **To drink:** water.

This isn't a strict rule. A curry, a stir-fry or a sandwich can follow the same proportions without being on a plate.

Portion sizes with your hand

Your hand is always with you, and it's sized to your body.



Quick portion guide using your hand. Adjust for your appetite and activity.

Glycemic index, in plain words

The **glycemic index (GI)** describes how quickly a carbohydrate food raises blood sugar.

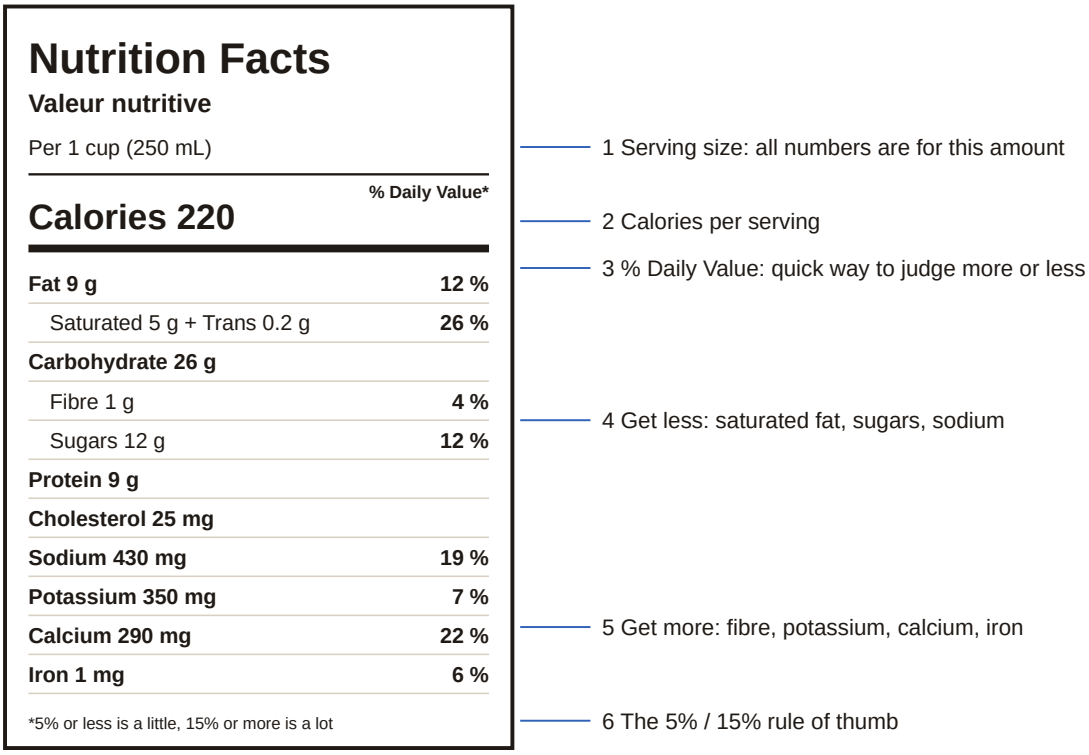
- **Lower GI:** most beans and lentils, oats, barley, most fruit, whole-grain and sourdough breads, pasta cooked al dente.
- **Higher GI:** white bread, most breakfast cereals, white rice, potatoes, rice cakes, sugary drinks.

You can lower the effect of a meal by adding **fibre, protein and fat**: toast with eggs and avocado raises blood sugar more slowly than toast with jam.

CHAPTER

Reading food labels

The Nutrition Facts table



How to read Canada's Nutrition Facts table. The US label shows the same information in a slightly different layout.

1. **Start with the serving size.** Every number below it is for that amount. If you eat twice as much, double everything.
2. **Look at calories** for that serving.
3. **Use the % Daily Value (%DV)** to judge quickly: **5% or less is a little, 15% or more is a lot.**
4. **Get less of:** saturated and trans fat, sugars, sodium.
5. **Get more of:** fibre, potassium, calcium, iron.
6. **Compare products** by making sure the serving sizes are similar.

The ingredient list

Ingredients are listed **by weight, from most to least**. If sugar or salt is in the first three, it's a big part of the food. In Canada, sugars are grouped together in brackets after the word "Sugars", so you can see all the sources at once.

Other names for sugar

Agave, brown rice syrup, cane juice, corn syrup, dextrose, fructose, glucose, high-fructose corn syrup, honey, invert sugar, maltose, maple syrup, molasses, sucrose, fruit juice concentrate.

The front-of-package symbol (Canada)

Since **January 1, 2026**, most prepackaged foods in Canada that are high in **saturated fat, sugars or sodium** must show a black-and-white magnifying-glass symbol on the front saying "High in". It's a quick warning sign: if you see it, check the table.

Allergens

Canadian labels must clearly declare the priority food allergens, gluten sources and added sulphites, either in the ingredient list or in a "Contains" statement:

Eggs · milk · mustard · peanuts · crustaceans and molluscs · fish · sesame seeds · soy · sulphites · tree nuts · wheat and triticale (and gluten from barley, oats, rye).

"May contain" statements are voluntary warnings about possible cross-contact.

Claims, decoded

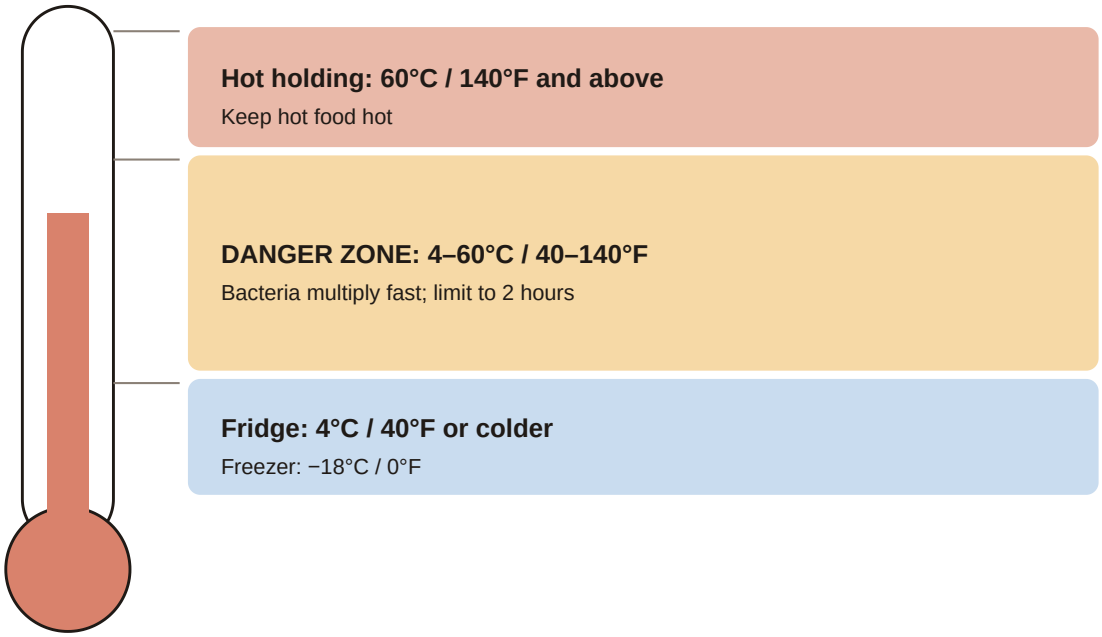
CLAIM	WHAT IT MEANS
"Source of fibre"	At least 2 g of fibre per serving
"High source of fibre"	At least 4 g per serving
"Low in sodium"	140 mg or less per serving
"Reduced in…"	At least 25% less than the regular version, but it can still be high
"Natural"	Not a nutrition claim. Says nothing about health
"Multigrain"	Several grains, but not necessarily whole grains. Look for "whole grain" first in the ingredients

CHAPTER

Food safety at home

Most foodborne illness at home comes from a few mistakes. Four habits prevent most of them: **clean, separate, cook, chill.**

The danger zone



Bacteria grow fastest between 4°C and 60°C (40°F–140°F).

- Don't leave perishable food at room temperature for more than **2 hours** (1 hour if it's very hot, above 32°C / 90°F).
- Keep your fridge at **4°C (40°F) or colder** and your freezer at **−18°C (0°F)**. Use a fridge thermometer.
- Thaw food in the fridge, in cold water or in the microwave, not on the counter.

Safe internal cooking temperatures

Use a food thermometer in the thickest part. Colour isn't a reliable test. These are Health Canada's guidelines:

FOOD	COOK TO
Poultry pieces (chicken, turkey, duck)	74°C (165°F)
Whole poultry	82°C (180°F)
Ground meat: beef, pork, lamb, veal	71°C (160°F)
Ground poultry	74°C (165°F)
Beef, veal, lamb steaks and roasts	63°C (145°F) medium-rare; 71°C (160°F) medium; 77°C (170°F) well done
Pork pieces and whole cuts	71°C (160°F)
Fish	70°C (158°F)
Egg dishes	74°C (165°F)
Leftovers, stuffing, hot dogs	74°C (165°F)

Clean and separate

- Wash hands with soap for 20 seconds before cooking and after handling raw meat, poultry, fish or eggs.
- Use separate cutting boards for raw meat and for ready-to-eat food.
- Don't rinse raw chicken; it splashes bacteria around the sink.
- Store raw meat on the **bottom shelf** of the fridge in a container, so it can't drip on other food.

How long food keeps in the fridge

FOOD	FRIDGE (4°C)
Raw ground meat and poultry	1–2 days
Raw chicken pieces	2–3 days
Raw steaks, chops and roasts	3–5 days
Raw fish	1–2 days
Cooked leftovers	2–4 days
Cooked rice	1–2 days; cool quickly and refrigerate within 1 hour
Opened deli meats	3–4 days
Hard-boiled eggs	7 days

When in doubt, throw it out. Most frozen food stays safe indefinitely at −18°C; quality is best within a few months.

CHAPTER

Myths and facts

MYTH	WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS
Carbs make you gain weight	Excess calories from any source do. Whole carbs with fibre are part of most healthy diets
Eating fat makes you fat	Fat is calorie-dense, but healthy fats are essential and help you feel full
Brown sugar and honey are much healthier than white sugar	They're all sugars. The tiny amounts of minerals don't make a real difference
You need to detox	Your liver and kidneys do that. Detox teas and juices aren't needed
Eating late at night causes weight gain	Total intake across the day matters more than the clock
Frozen vegetables are less nutritious	They're frozen soon after picking and are often just as nutritious as fresh
Eggs are bad for your heart	For most healthy people, eggs can be part of a balanced diet
Gluten-free is healthier	Only for people with coeliac disease or gluten sensitivity. Many gluten-free products are more refined
Skipping breakfast slows your metabolism	It doesn't. Eat breakfast if it helps you, skip it if it doesn't

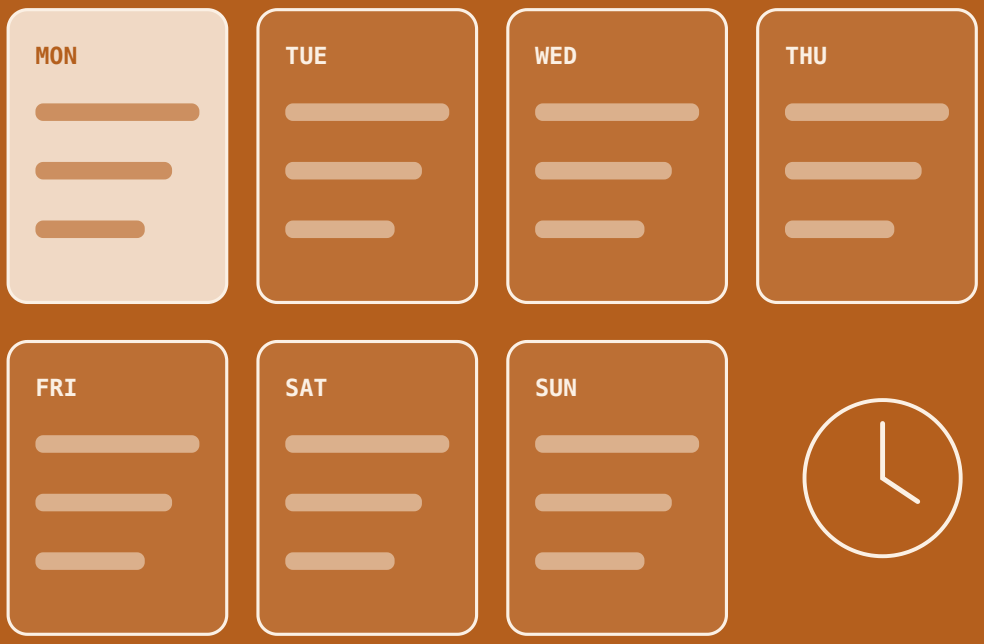
A note on special diets: if you have diabetes, kidney disease, high blood pressure, food allergies or another medical condition, a registered dietitian can give advice tailored to you. In Canada, many provinces offer free dietitian advice by phone.

CHAPTER

Your kitchen spice guide

Spices add flavour without salt, sugar or calories.

SPICE	FLAVOUR	TRY IT IN
Turmeric	Warm, earthy, golden colour	Curries, lentils, scrambled eggs, rice
Cumin	Smoky, nutty	Chilli, tacos, roasted vegetables, dals
Coriander seed	Citrusy, gentle	Curries, marinades, pickles
Cinnamon	Sweet, warm	Oats, baking, stews, coffee
Paprika (smoked)	Smoky, sweet	Roast chicken, potatoes, eggs
Garam masala	Warm blend	Finish curries, roast vegetables
Black pepper	Sharp heat	Almost everything; helps turmeric absorption
Ginger	Zesty heat	Stir-fries, tea, soups, baking
Curry leaves	Aromatic, nutty	South Indian tempering for dals and coconut dishes
Chilli flakes	Heat	Pasta, pizza, stir-fries
Oregano	Earthy, herbal	Tomato sauces, Greek salads, roast vegetables
Garlic powder	Savoury	Rubs, dressings, roasted vegetables



The Recipe Vault · Vol. 04

Simple & Quick

A 7-day food plan for busy weeks

SchoolAura

SCHOOLAURA.COM · FOD 110

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CHAPTER

How this plan works

This plan is for busy weeks: work, school runs, late evenings. It feeds **two adults for seven days** with balanced meals, and most dinners take **20 minutes or less** on the night. Double everything for a family of four.

The secret isn't fast recipes. It's **cooking once, eating twice**: a 90-minute prep session on Sunday makes the weekdays easy.

The rules

1. **Prep on Sunday.** Cook a grain, roast a tray of vegetables, make a soup, boil eggs and wash greens.
2. **Cook dinner three nights.** Leftovers become lunches. Two other nights take under 15 minutes.
3. **Keep breakfast boring.** Two or three good options on rotation saves daily decisions.
4. **Shop once.** One list, organised by aisle, for the whole week.
5. **Plan one flexible night.** Leftovers, eggs on toast or a night out. Real life happens.

What you need

- 2 large sheet pans, a large pot, a large frying pan
- 8–10 food storage containers with lids, plus a few jars for oats
- A sharp knife, a large cutting board and a timer

CHAPTER

The 7-day plan

DAY	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER
Mon	Overnight oats: berry	Tomato lentil soup + bread	One-pan lemon herb chicken & vegetables
Tue	Veggie scramble wrap	Chicken grain bowl (from Monday)	15-minute garlic shrimp noodles
Wed	Overnight oats: peanut butter banana	Tomato lentil soup	Black bean & corn tacos
Thu	Greek yogurt bowl	Chickpea & tuna salad	Sheet-pan sausage, peppers & potatoes
Fri	Veggie scramble wrap	Sausage & veg bowl (from Thursday)	Spinach & white bean pasta
Sat	Banana oat pancakes	Leftover pasta or eat out	Chicken fried rice
Sun	Eggs on toast with avocado	Soup or salad with what's left	Flexible night, then prep for next week

Snacks: fruit, a handful of nuts, yogurt, carrot sticks with hummus, boiled eggs, cheese and crackers.

Sunday prep: 90 minutes

Work in this order so the oven and stove are busy at the same time.

TIME	DO THIS
0:00	Heat the oven to 425°F (220°C). Put a pot of rice or quinoa on
0:05	Start the Tomato Lentil Soup (it simmers by itself)
0:15	Chop vegetables for Monday's tray and the week: peppers, onions, broccoli, carrots
0:30	Roast a tray of mixed vegetables for bowls and wraps (25 min)
0:35	Boil 6 eggs for 10 minutes, then cool in cold water
0:45	Make 2 jars of overnight oats
0:55	Wash and dry salad greens; store with a paper towel
1:05	Cool the rice quickly on a tray, then refrigerate
1:10	Portion the soup into containers. Freeze two portions if you like
1:20	Clean up and stick the plan on the fridge

Rice safety: spread cooked rice on a tray to cool quickly and refrigerate within 1 hour. Use it within 1–2 days, and reheat until steaming hot.

CHAPTER

Shopping list

For two adults for one week. Tick what you already have before you shop.

Produce

- 2 lemons, 2 limes
- 1 bag baby spinach, 1 head romaine
- 3 bell peppers, 2 onions, 1 red onion
- 1 head broccoli, 4 carrots, 1 zucchini
- 1 kg baby potatoes
- 1 head garlic, a thumb of ginger
- Green onions, fresh parsley or coriander
- 2 avocados, 6 bananas, 2 cups berries (fresh or frozen)
- 1 cucumber, cherry tomatoes

Protein and dairy

- 6 bone-in chicken thighs or 4 breasts
- 400 g raw shrimp (frozen is fine)
- 4 sausages (about 400 g)
- 2 dozen eggs
- 1 kg plain Greek yogurt
- Milk or unsweetened plant drink
- 150 g cheddar or feta, parmesan

Pantry

- 1 can each: black beans, chickpeas, white beans, corn
- 1 can tuna, 1 can (796 ml) crushed tomatoes
- 1 cup dried red lentils
- Rolled oats, chia seeds, peanut butter
- Rice or quinoa, 450 g pasta, 300 g egg or rice noodles
- Whole-wheat tortillas, bread
- Vegetable or chicken stock
- Soy sauce, olive oil, honey, Dijon mustard, salsa, hummus
- Cumin, smoked paprika, chilli flakes, dried oregano

CHAPTER

Breakfast

BREAKFAST · NO COOK

RECIPE 01

Overnight Oats, Three Ways

Five minutes the night before, zero minutes in the morning.

Serves 1 per jar | Prep 5 min | Chill overnight

INGREDIENTS

Base, per jar

- 45 g (½ cup) rolled oats
- 120 ml (½ cup) milk or plant drink
- 60 g (¼ cup) Greek yogurt
- 1 tbsp chia seeds
- 1 tsp honey or maple syrup (optional)

Choose a flavour

- **Berry:** ½ cup berries, a little lemon zest
- **Peanut butter banana:** 1 tbsp peanut butter, ½ sliced banana, pinch of cinnamon
- **Apple pie:** ½ grated apple, ½ tsp cinnamon, 1 tbsp chopped walnuts

METHOD

1. Stir the base ingredients together in a jar.
2. Add your flavour, stir, and close the lid.
3. Refrigerate overnight (at least 6 hours). Keeps for 3 days.
4. Eat cold, or microwave for 1–2 minutes with a splash more milk.

Five-Minute Veggie Scramble Wraps

Use leftover roasted vegetables from Sunday for an almost instant hot breakfast.

Serves 2 Cook 5 min

INGREDIENTS

- 4 large eggs
- 1 cup leftover roasted vegetables, chopped
- A handful of baby spinach
- 30 g cheddar or feta
- 2 whole-wheat tortillas
- Salt, pepper, hot sauce or salsa

METHOD

1. Warm the vegetables in a non-stick pan over medium heat for 1 minute. Add the spinach until it wilts.
2. Whisk the eggs with salt and pepper and pour into the pan. Stir gently until just set.
3. Sprinkle with cheese, divide between the tortillas, add salsa and roll up.

NOTES

- Wrap in foil to eat on the go.

Banana Oat Pancakes

Three main ingredients, naturally sweet, and ready in 15 minutes.

Serves 2 (about 8 small pancakes) | Prep 5 min | Cook 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 1 large ripe banana
- 2 large eggs
- 45 g (½ cup) rolled oats
- ½ tsp baking powder, pinch of cinnamon and salt
- Butter or oil for the pan
- Yogurt and berries, to serve

METHOD

1. Blend everything until smooth. Rest for 5 minutes to thicken.
2. Heat a lightly greased non-stick pan over medium-low heat.
3. Cook 2 tablespoons of batter per pancake for 2 minutes, until bubbles form, then flip and cook 1 minute more.
4. Serve with yogurt and berries.

Greek Yogurt Bowls

High protein and endlessly flexible.

Serves 1 Prep 2 min

INGREDIENTS

- 200 g (¾ cup) plain Greek yogurt
- ½ cup berries or chopped fruit
- 2 tbsp granola or toasted oats
- 1 tbsp nuts or seeds
- Drizzle of honey (optional)

METHOD

1. Spoon the yogurt into a bowl.
2. Top with fruit, granola and nuts, and drizzle with honey if you like.

CHAPTER

Lunch

LUNCH · MAKE AHEAD

RECIPE 05

Big-Batch Tomato Lentil Soup

Thick, warming and very cheap. Makes enough for four lunches; freezes well.

Serves 6 | Prep 10 min | Cook 30 min

INGREDIENTS

- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 onion, chopped
- 2 carrots, chopped
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp smoked paprika, pinch of chilli flakes
- 200 g (1 cup) dried red lentils, rinsed
- 1 can (796 ml) crushed tomatoes
- 1.25 L (5 cups) vegetable or chicken stock
- 2 handfuls spinach
- Juice of ½ lemon, salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Heat the oil in a large pot over medium heat. Cook the onion and carrots for 6–8 minutes until soft.
2. Add the garlic and spices and stir for 1 minute.
3. Add the lentils, tomatoes and stock. Bring to a boil, then simmer for 20–25 minutes, stirring now and then, until the lentils are soft.
4. Stir in the spinach and lemon juice. Season well. Blend partly for a creamier soup.
5. Cool, then portion into containers. Keeps 4 days in the fridge or 3 months in the freezer.

Chicken Grain Bowls

Leftovers become a fresh lunch. Pack in the morning in two minutes.

Serves 2 | Prep 5 min

INGREDIENTS

- 2 cups cooked rice or quinoa (from Sunday)
- Leftover lemon herb chicken, sliced
- 1 cup roasted vegetables
- Cucumber, cherry tomatoes, spinach
- 2 tbsp hummus or yogurt

Quick dressing

- 2 tbsp olive oil, 1 tbsp lemon juice, 1 tsp Dijon, 1 tsp honey, salt

METHOD

1. Divide the grains between two containers.
2. Top with chicken, vegetables and salad.
3. Add a spoon of hummus. Pack the dressing separately.

Chickpea & Tuna Salad

Protein, fibre and crunch in ten minutes. Lasts two days in the fridge.

Serves 2 Prep 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 1 can (540 ml) chickpeas, drained and rinsed
- 1 can tuna, drained
- ½ cucumber, diced
- 1 cup cherry tomatoes, halved
- ¼ red onion, finely chopped
- Handful of parsley, chopped
- 2 tbsp olive oil, juice of 1 lemon, salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Toss everything together in a large bowl.
2. Taste and add more lemon, salt or pepper.
3. Eat as it is, over greens or stuffed into a wrap.

NOTES

- Vegetarian? Swap the tuna for feta and a chopped hard-boiled egg.

CHAPTER

Dinner

DINNER · ONE PAN

RECIPE 08

One-Pan Lemon Herb Chicken & Vegetables

Everything roasts together on one tray. Make extra for Tuesday's lunch bowls.

Serves 2 + leftovers | Prep 10 min | Cook 35–40 min

INGREDIENTS

- 6 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs
- 500 g baby potatoes, halved
- 1 head broccoli, cut into florets
- 1 red onion, cut into wedges
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 1 lemon, zest and juice
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp dried oregano, 1 tsp smoked paprika, salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 425°F (220°C).
2. Toss the potatoes and onion with 1 tbsp oil and salt on a large sheet pan. Roast for 10 minutes.
3. Mix the remaining oil with lemon zest, juice, garlic, oregano, paprika, salt and pepper. Rub over the chicken.
4. Push the potatoes to the sides, add the chicken skin-side up and roast for 20 minutes.
5. Add the broccoli, toss with the pan juices, and roast for 8–10 minutes more, until the chicken reaches 74°C (165°F) and the skin is crisp.

15-Minute Garlic Shrimp Noodles

Faster than takeout. Have everything chopped before you start; it moves quickly.

Serves 2 | Prep 5 min | Cook 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 150 g egg or rice noodles
- 250 g raw shrimp, peeled
- 1 pepper, thinly sliced
- 2 cups spinach or bok choy
- 4 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tsp grated ginger
- 1 tbsp oil

Sauce

3 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tbsp honey, 1 tsp sesame oil, 1 tbsp lime juice, pinch of chilli flakes

METHOD

1. Cook the noodles according to the packet. Drain and rinse briefly.
2. Mix the sauce ingredients in a cup.
3. Heat the oil in a large pan over high heat. Cook the shrimp for 2 minutes until pink; remove.
4. Add the pepper for 2 minutes, then the garlic and ginger for 30 seconds.
5. Add the noodles, greens, shrimp and sauce. Toss for 1–2 minutes until glossy.

Black Bean & Corn Tacos

Ready in 15 minutes from cans you already have.

Serves 2 | Prep 5 min | Cook 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 1 can (540 ml) black beans, drained and rinsed
- 1 cup canned or frozen corn
- 1 tsp cumin, 1 tsp smoked paprika, salt
- 6 small tortillas
- 1 avocado, mashed with lime juice and salt
- Salsa, shredded lettuce, cheese or yogurt

METHOD

1. Warm the beans and corn in a pan with the spices and a splash of water for 5 minutes. Mash about a third of the beans.
2. Warm the tortillas in a dry pan or the microwave.
3. Fill with beans, avocado, salsa, lettuce and cheese.

Sheet-Pan Sausage, Peppers & Potatoes

Hands-off comfort food. Make enough for Friday's lunch.

Serves 2 + leftovers | Prep 10 min | Cook 30 min

INGREDIENTS

- 4 sausages (about 400 g)
- 500 g baby potatoes, halved
- 2 peppers, cut into strips
- 1 onion, cut into wedges
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp smoked paprika, 1 tsp dried oregano, salt and pepper

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 425°F (220°C).
2. Toss the potatoes with half the oil and seasoning on a sheet pan. Roast for 10 minutes.
3. Add the peppers, onion, remaining oil and the sausages. Roast for 20–22 minutes, turning the sausages once, until cooked through (71°C / 160°F for pork, 74°C / 165°F for chicken sausages).

Spinach & White Bean Pasta

A pantry pasta with garlic, lemon and parmesan that tastes far better than its effort.

Serves 2 + 1 lunch | Prep 5 min | Cook 15 min

INGREDIENTS

- 250 g short pasta
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 4 garlic cloves, sliced
- Pinch of chilli flakes
- 1 can (540 ml) white beans, drained and rinsed
- 3 large handfuls spinach
- Zest and juice of 1 lemon
- 40 g parmesan, grated, plus extra to serve

METHOD

1. Cook the pasta in well-salted water. Save a mug of pasta water before draining.
2. Meanwhile, warm the oil and garlic in a large pan over medium heat until the garlic is lightly golden. Add the chilli.
3. Add the beans and cook for 3 minutes, mashing a few.
4. Add the drained pasta, spinach, lemon zest and juice, parmesan and a splash of pasta water. Toss until glossy.

Chicken Fried Rice

The best use for cold leftover rice. Use any vegetables you have.

Serves 2 | Prep 5 min | Cook 10 min

INGREDIENTS

- 3 cups cold cooked rice (from Sunday, used within 1–2 days)
- 1–1½ cups cooked chicken, chopped
- 1 cup frozen peas and carrots, or chopped vegetables
- 2 large eggs, beaten
- 2 green onions, sliced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 tbsp soy sauce, 1 tsp sesame oil
- 1 tbsp oil

METHOD

1. Heat the oil in a large pan or wok over high heat. Scramble the eggs quickly and set aside.
2. Add the vegetables, garlic and green onion whites for 2 minutes.
3. Add the rice, breaking up clumps, and stir-fry for 4 minutes until hot and slightly crisp.
4. Add the chicken, eggs, soy sauce and sesame oil. Toss for 2 minutes until steaming hot. Top with green onions.

CHAPTER

Leftovers & budget

The leftover remix

YOU HAVE	TURN IT INTO
Roast chicken	Grain bowls, wraps, fried rice, soup
Roasted vegetables	Scramble wraps, pasta, blended into soup
Cooked rice	Fried rice (within 1–2 days)
Soup	Lunches, or a sauce for pasta
Half a can of beans	Tacos, salads, mashed on toast
Spinach about to wilt	Smoothies, soup, pasta, eggs
Overripe bananas	Pancakes, oats, freeze for smoothies

Ten ways to spend less

1. Shop with a list and stick to it.
2. Check the fridge and cupboards before you shop.
3. Buy frozen vegetables and fruit: cheaper, no waste, just as nutritious.
4. Buy rice, oats, lentils and pasta in bigger bags.
5. Use beans and lentils for some meals instead of meat.
6. Buy whole chickens or bone-in thighs; they cost less per kilo.
7. Choose store brands for staples.
8. Cook once, eat twice.
9. Freeze bread, leftovers and ripe fruit before they go off.
10. Plan one "use it up" meal every week.

CHAPTER

Your weekly planner

Photocopy or print this page each week.

DAY	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER	PREP NOTE
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

Shopping list